

Tacit Coordination in Distributed Maintenance Teams: An Interpretive Field Study

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Abstract

Drawing on eleven months of observation across two regional maintenance depots, we argue that formal handover documentation systematically fails to capture the cues technicians actually use to decide whether an inherited job is safe to continue. Coordination is sustained instead through informal narrative retelling at shift boundaries.

Findings

Technicians described written handovers as accurate but insufficient. What mattered was whether the outgoing technician seemed confident, whether they volunteered caveats without being asked, and whether their account of the fault was internally coherent. None of these signals appear in the handover form.

When depots introduced a structured digital handover tool, narrative retelling did not disappear; it migrated to the car park and the locker room, where it was no longer observable to supervisors. We interpret this as displacement rather than replacement.

Discussion

The implication is not that documentation should be abandoned but that a handover artifact which cannot carry uncertainty will be routed around. Any claim that digital handover improves safety must be evaluated against what it displaces, not only against what it records.

Limitations

Two depots in one region, one observer, no comparison site. Findings are analytic rather than statistical generalizations.